

Kansas City's Water Heaters

I work for Neighborhood and Community Services in Kansas City, Missouri, in the Minor Home Repair and Weatherization program. I have worked in weatherization since 1986, and performed energy audits prior to that in Fairbanks, Alaska. Robert T. Jackson has administered the program in Kansas City for more than 25 years. He has secured grants from the state of Missouri (DOE), the local electric company (Kansas City Power and Light), the local natural gas company (Missouri Gas and Energy), and several other smaller utilities.

Our programs in Kansas City replace between 50 and 100 water heaters a year for our low-income clients. As these pictures show, some of these water heaters are very dangerous.



Here are the energy auditors who do the work (back row left to right): Rocky Henry, Richard Smith, and Gary Clark. (Front row) Paul Stallings and Francisco Murgia.



This photo shows a newly installed gas water heater before the overflow pipe was installed. Overflow pipes are very important; they safely divert hot water in case the pressure relief valve goes off. At this height, the scalding hot water could blow out onto a person's face.



This rusty unit was rotted by years of water leaking on it from the pipes above.



More rust and hot water leaking onto the floor.



Kansas City Weatherization Director Bob Jackson and his assistant, Bonnie Jackson.



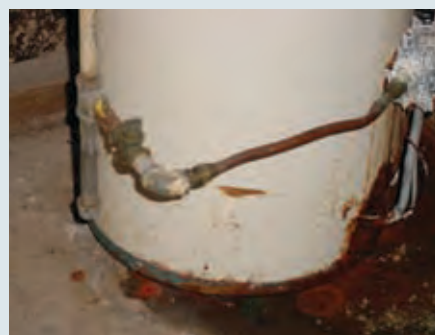
This is another plugged and rusty unit that the client continued to use.



These two rusted-out water heaters were only a few years old.



We properly vented this unit that was dangerously vented into the living space.



This water heater had a completely corroded gas valve, and water leaks rusted out the bottom.

Our programs in Kansas City replace between 50 and 100 water heaters a year for our low-income clients. As these pictures show, some of these water heaters are very dangerous.



Here is a close-up of the corroded gas valve.



More top rot.



More rust and hot water leaking onto the floor.



This is a unit with a potentially deadly problem. The black deposit on the side is caused by abundant CO leaking from around the gas valve.

These are all real situations, and all of these bad units were replaced. All of these pictures were taken by City of Kansas City, Missouri, employees Stephen Boniello, Rockie Henry, Richard Smith, Thomas Andrews, and myself. **H_e**

—John Quimby

John Quimby works at Neighborhood and Community Services in Kansas City, Missouri, in the Minor Home Repair and Weatherization program. Contact him at john_quimby@kcmo.org.